



PITCH PRESENTATION TIPS

NEW SOCIAL VENTURES

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Introduction

Accumulated over the years from experience with countless NVC, GNVC, SNVC pitches.

These are worth reading and re-reading. There is no excuse for violating the mechanical tips, i.e., label the axes of all graphs.

Divided into four (somewhat arbitrary) categories.

- Content
- Slides
- Presentation
- Questions and Answers

Content - General

This is a sales pitch, not an academic exercise, so sell.

You are telling the story of your venture – think carefully about the narrative structure that tells the story most effectively.

Describe/demonstrate all tangible progress you have made.
Celebrate your successes.

Content – Demonstrate expertise

Demonstrate deep knowledge, practical understanding, and competence.

Demonstrate expertise – understand the research on the problem you are addressing, and the history of attempts to address the problem. But do this quickly.

Get into enough detail so that we really believe that you know your business. Ask yourself where should we be granular.

Content – convince us it is a viable venture

Convince us that your venture will work – not by assertion but with as much evidence as possible.

Assume that your audience is skeptical and your job is to convince them that your business model is a good one. Ask yourself why might this venture fail and try to work on showing why the apparent weakest link should not be a concern.

(Don't tell us why the venture might fail, however.)

Content –tell us what you do quickly

Explain what you do at the beginning of the presentation. A pitch is not a murder mystery.

It is letdown to describe a huge problem and a venture that addresses a very small piece of it.

If you want to start with a story that is more than one minute long, preface it with a one sentence description of what you do and for whom, then tell the story.

First 30 seconds to two minutes of presentation should be a description of the problem and what you do to solve it. Make it as emotional and personal as possible – give us a story, use visual aids.

Content – present the business

Your goal is to present your business/venture, not just the problem you address or your solution to a problem.

1. Here is a problem (1-2 minutes).
2. Here is an innovative solution to the problem. (2-3 minutes)
3. Here is how we will build a sustainable organization by implementing our solution to the problem. (5-7 minutes)

There is a tendency to spend lots of time on what is easy about your business and very little on what is difficult. Reverse it. Don't spend five minutes telling us that hunger is a problem in sub-Saharan Africa and one minute about how you will build an organization that impacts the problem."

Content- miscellaneous

Do not forget to look for analogs to drive assumptions about key parameters and to demonstrate the strengths and weaknesses of business model choices. Analogs are very powerful – use them.

Explain how your venture is innovative.

Do not relate your personal journey of how you got interested in this problem unless it makes tangible contribution to your pitch, such as why you are committed to the issue. Keep it short.

Keep technical descriptions as simple as possible, but no simpler.

Content – Avoid the curse of knowledge

Avoid the curse of knowledge. Practice your first two minutes on friends who know nothing about your venture and ask them to tell you what your venture does and what problem it solves. If they don't get it right, edit your presentation, not your friends.

Avoid acronyms, jargon, and unexplained analogies to other products that your audience may not know.

Content – financials

The goal of your financial model is to communicate the economics of the venture, the likely costs associated with building the business, and plausible financial outcomes if it is successful. It is not to tell us what will happen in great detail. Therefore, it is important to communicate key assumptions and the justifications underlying the assumptions. Figure out the narrative of this part.

Show us the unit economics of your venture. This demonstrates the key way in which your venture will work financially. Explain why you are confident that unit revenue can exceed/equal unit cost (or if there is a shortfall, explain why you believe that philanthropy is a plausible strategy for making up the difference).

Content - financials

Your financial projections should be based on a plausible success scenario, i.e., “if things go well we could expect...” It does not and should not represent expected cashflows that would incorporate the (substantial) probability that the venture will fail. You should not use the word “conservative” to describe your projections; quite the contrary, they should be aspirational.

Include an ask – how much money, what you will use it for, and what you will achieve before you need more. Think about asking for less money – enough to resolve the next critical uncertainties, not all of them and not enough to become sustainable.

Content – competition (part 1)

First, you should demonstrate how your venture creates value for target customers/beneficiaries relative to their next best alternative.

Many groups build a matrix with features on one side and competitors on the other. Although potentially useful, it is insufficient to say, “look, our product is the only one with all the boxes checked.”

Explain why chosen features are critical, need to be combined, and create substantial incremental value to your target customers.

Be sure to consider the right set of competitors – do the research.

Don't ignore an organization whose offering is close but has had no success, rather tell us why.

Content – competition (part 2)

Second, you should separately discuss your long-run competitive positioning conditional on being successful.

This does not require zero future entry into the market, just how you envision a successful launch will position you to do well against competition that is **inevitable** for almost all your businesses.

It is contradictory to tell us how straightforward it will be for you to succeed, but the successful well-resourced organization providing complementary products/services could not or would not compete.

Organizations that are doing something similar to you but with different target customers, are potential competitors, but they can also validate your value proposition.

Content – marketing/launch

In developing your launch marketing plan, think carefully about whom you are selling to, how you will reach them and how you will convince them to buy. Try to make some choices about which ways to reach customers are better than other ways.

A list of ten different marketing/sales tactics is a list not a strategy.

Develop and explain your launch strategy – what exactly are you going to do to bring your product to market and sell to your initial target market.

Content – lean startup

Take the lean startup idea seriously.

Narrow your initial geographical, customer, and product scope as much as you can but make sure that you can learn and adapt from your initial market entry.

Outsource as much as you can at first without giving up control over critical aspects of your venture.

Content – team

Goal is to be convincing that your team can execute the business model that you are pitching.

Tell us the skills you need to make the business succeed and the relevant expertise and experience key people bring to the business.

Acknowledge gaps. It is better to show you understand whom you need than to suggest something critical is not. Funders understand that if you get funded it becomes easier to fill gaps.

Explain how advisers will help you succeed. Advisers should agree to be listed as such, not just people who have given you advice.

Don't start pitch with your team unless your team is the main reason why someone would want to invest.

Content – ending

Make you ending powerful.

Too many teams finish the financials or team slide and then act kind of surprised that there are no more slides and say something like “I guess it’s time for questions.”

Your conclusion should demonstrate passion and commitment. Why should the audience believe in you? Why do you want them totally engaged in your business in the future? How will you change the world?

But don’t be hokey – be genuine.

Slides - general

Reduce the number of words and make the slides as visual as possible. Too much text and the audience is reading the slide and not listening to you. Avoid distracting graphics that serve no expository purpose.

Use dark typeface on a light background or the reverse.

Use large font sizes. The smallest font size should be half the age of the oldest person in the room.

Only use animation if it serves a purpose, i.e., if you need to walk the audience through a complicated structure or process.

Make headings conclusions if possible. Rather than “Financials” say “We Will be Profitable in Year 3”. Or don’t use headings or make them footings.

Slides – numbers, final slide

Show the unit economics by itself on a single slide.

Highlight assumptions and their implications rather than simply reporting bottom lines numbers.

No slide should have more than 100 digits. Count and pare it down - seriously.

Move details to the appendix.

Label the axes of all graphs and include units.

Think about what you want the audience to see during Q&A and make that your last slide.

Presentation

Demonstrate passion, enthusiasm and commitment.

Either introduce everyone by name at the beginning or have every person introduce themselves the first time they speak.

Practice your presentation and practice answering questions.

Be sure that your presentation is within the time limit.

Make a connection with your audience. Stand in front of the podium.

Make sure that those not presenting do not distract attention from the speaker. Stand to the side, stand still and pay attention. Don't block the screens.

Know your audience. Do not belabor an issue they get immediately.

Questions & Answers - Introduction

The Q&A is part of the pitch; you should act as if you have 25 minutes to pitch your venture, not 11.

- The Q&A should be viewed as an opportunity to present details that you had to cut from your pitch.
- Anticipate questions and be prepared to answer them.

Although you have less control over the Q&A, do not mistake less control for no control.

- It is your job to manage the judges.
- You choose whom to call on.
- A judge that keeps asking follow-up or makes a speech is your problem to manage.

Questions & Answers

Listen to the questions.

Answer the questions that are asked. This is not a political talk show or press conference. If you don't have an answer, say that you will have to get back to the judge later. Then really do get back to the judge later.

One person should answer a question. Assign responsibilities so everyone on your team knows whose question it is; do not fumble over who will answer the question. Second best is for one person to distribute each question to the appropriate person, i.e., "Jill, can you take this one?"

A second person should only jump in if absolutely necessary.

Questions & Answers

Only people in the front of the room on your team can answer questions. You can bring additional people up for Q&A but nobody from your team who is sitting in the audience can speak. This rule is will be enforced.

Answers should be short and to the point. There is nothing that makes a judge unhappier than not getting to ask his or her question because you took too long answering that other judge's stupid question. You can end your short answer by saying "does that answer your question?" or "would you like more details?"

Your goal is not to survive unscathed but to answer the questions as best you can. Do not get into an argument with a judge; agree to disagree and offer to follow up after the presentation.

Questions & Answers

A team member should be at the computer and ready to jump to whatever slide is needed (presentation or appendix) rather than clicking through the entire presentation to find it which is distracting and time-consuming (especially if there is animation).

It will be necessary to have a list of slides and slide numbers to do this. If you type in the slide number and enter, it will go to relevant slide number (in PowerPoint or Acrobat).

It is impressive if you have an appendix slide prepared for every question that you will likely be asked.

Questions & Answers

Here is a bad thing that we have seen happen: someone asks a fundamental question that you had already addressed in the main presentation. So you infer the judge must be asking a different question and that is the one you answer. The result is you have not clarified something fundamental that this judge (and maybe others) missed and the judge thinks you have not figured out something fundamental because you avoided the question. So listen carefully answer the question that is asked, even if you have already addressed it.

Questions & Answers – Follow-up

People often say “yes” when asked “did that answer your question?” even if it didn’t.

Or they say “sort of” which leads to a difficult decision.

“Would you like me to say more?” or “Do you have a follow-up?” and if yes, then ask for specifics.